

Reference Letter Guide

To document that you possess extraordinary ability, we will need you to obtain reference letters discussing your original contributions and how you have risen to the very top of your field. Strong reference letters will use plain language that states how your accomplishments and research have impacted your field and industry. Strong letters will also include clear, easy-to-understand metrics/data regarding measurable improvements and innovations. The letters should be easy for a non-technical person to read.

Process

You will be responsible for drafting the content of the letters. Below please find a summary of the process.

1. Your Case Team will confirm the final list of reference writers and provide you with instructions on how to draft the letters.
2. You will draft all the letters and send them to your Case Team for review.
3. Your Case Team will provide you with detailed feedback for each of the letters.
4. You will review changes and provide any missing information. You will send updated letters to your Case Team.
5. Your Case Team will review the updated letters and confirm that the letters are final and ready for you to send to the reference writers for review and approval.
6. You will work with your references to obtain the signed letters. If a reference writer is unwilling to sign the letter or wants to make changes to the content of the letter, please contact your Case Team.
7. You will provide the signed letters to your Case Team.

Do not send the letters to your reference writers for signature until we confirm you may do so. We kindly request that you submit all drafts for review at the same time so that we may assess the strength of your case and the totality of the evidence.

Once we receive all of the signed letters, we will begin to work on your O-1 Memorandum. This is the most time-consuming work for the petition on our end. The memo will set forth the legal arguments that you satisfy the required standard and summarize the evidence submitted to back up those claims. The typical preparation time for this is four to six weeks.

Framework for Letters

Generally, the letters should follow the following framework. Note that we do not want the letters to be exact copies of each other. The letters should each cover the accomplishments included in your final Reference Letter Sheet.

- **Introduction.** State the purpose of the letter and identify area of expertise. If the author can provide an opinion on your national or international reputation in the field, they should do so here.
- **Author's Qualifications.** The letter should include a description of the author, including their professional education and training, areas of expertise, present position, memberships, accomplishments, publications, etc. Attaching a copy of the letter author's

current resume or a link to the letter author's public profile is helpful. There should be one sentence at the end of this section linking the author's qualifications to their ability to opine on your reputation and work in your area of expertise.

- **Author's Relationship to You.** Letter should state whether you and the author have collaborated in any way. If the author is describing your collaboration with other people (including themselves), the author should explain your unique and distinguishable role and contributions within the team. If the author does not know you personally, the author should say so and note that their comments are based on your reputation, standing in the field, presentations, articles, etc. Note that the author may still be considered "independent" even if they have cited to your article(s) or met you briefly at a conference, for example.
- **Your Accomplishments.** The letter should describe your distinct accomplishments and contributions to your field of endeavor. For each contribution discussed, the letter should:
 - Provide context and introduction to the area of your work. Once you've established the big picture, make clear how your contribution fits into this.
 - Explain what problem, challenge, or need your work addressed.
 - Describe your solution. What did you achieve and how did you achieve it through your research?
 - Establish that your contribution is original. Is it an all new technology? Did it improve upon or replace existing technology or processes? If there is improvement over prior technology, do you have metrics/data to support that?
 - Establish that your contribution is significant. What impact did it have on the academic community, a specific industry (or group of industries), and/or other arenas, such as the environment or economy?
 - Explain the impact of your contribution on a broader scale. What are the real-world implications and practical applications? What are the benefits to end users/products? Does it make a device faster, increase battery life, etc.?
 - Discuss products or intellectual property developed through your work, such as publications, presentations, grants, patents, awards, etc.
 - List any use of your work by other researchers or experts in the field, such as citations. Has your work been used in a specific industry? If so, by whom? What has been the impact of this use?
 - If describing your employment in a critical capacity, the letter should touch on how your work directly affected and elevated the organization.
 - Provide metrics such as sales figures, revenue, or readership wherever possible.
 - Confirm how unusual and distinguished your abilities and accomplishments are within your field of expertise.
- **Conclusion.** The letter should restate your national and international reputation within your field of endeavor.
- **Signature.** The signature should list the letter writer's contact information, including full name, title, email, and phone number. Once the content of the letter is finalized, the letter writer will need to sign the letter in ink and provide you with a scanned copy of the letter, which you will then email to our office. We do not require the original letter.

Sample Letter #1: Academic Reference for Science Researcher

[LETTERHEAD]

[Date]

Department of Homeland Security
U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services
Regional Service Center

Re: [NAME OF BENEFICIARY]'s – Support for O-1 Visa Petition

To Whom It May Concern:

I'm pleased to attest to [BENEFICIARY]'s remarkable research contributions in the field of [Area of expertise]. Original and influential, [BENEFICIARY]'s work has powerfully impacted the scientific field of ABC and accelerated the scientific adoption of his ABC technology for [function, industry, area]. His research has won international acclaim throughout the ABC community and among research leaders.

As for my own qualifications to provide this recommendation, since YEAR I have served at the [Name of University] not only as a Full Professor but also as Senior Director of Research. I received my Ph.D. in X from [Name of University] in YEAR and have approximately 35 years of experience in studying [Area of expertise]. I have supervised more than 10 post-doctoral researchers and more than 25 PhD students in the field. Thus, I am uniquely qualified to assess [BENEFICIARY]'s standing amongst his peers. Based on his performance and more importantly because of his original contributions and well-earned reputation, I can state with confidence that [BENEFICIARY] is unparalleled among his peers in the field of [area of expertise], specifically with regard to his groundbreaking innovations regarding ABC and their improvements in data efficiency.

Before obtaining his PhD from the [Name of University] in YEAR, [BENEFICIARY] served as a graduate researcher in different influential groups in YEAR at [Name of University] and in YEAR at [Name of University]. I supervised his PhD work, which focused on ABC technologies. Using original research, [BENEFICIARY] built better models that directly impact different fields, including X, Y, and Z. This allows us to build increasingly more accurate models and expand our understanding of X. Consequently, this has the potential to [Impact of Work].

[BENEFICIARY]'s scientific contributions at the University, as well as his extraordinary subsequent work with other distinguished institutions, prompted me to entrust him with supervising the first publication of three PhD students. He proposed and oversaw the development of a new method for aligning data from different experiments. [BENEFICIARY] demonstrated a natural talent in supervising the students and igniting in them an enthusiasm

for the project. Moreover, his previous work on ABC has been widely adopted. It has been employed in more than fifteen publications from other groups that build better models using [BENEFICIARY]'s framework. My own group is working on a follow up project predicting the responses of X, which is essentially facilitated by the methodological developments as well as further, yet unpublished improvements proposed by [BENEFICIARY]. Thus, the significance of his contributions cannot be overstated.

Because of the immense research applicability and potential implications his groundbreaking modeling approach, [BENEFICIARY] was awarded a spotlight presentation for his research papers at the most competitive [NAME OF CONFERENCE] in YEAR. Out of more than ten thousand submitted projects, this prestigious award is only offered by the conference to those that demonstrate original research offering practical implementation or potential for high impact. The award offers but one example of the fact that [BENEFICIARY] is recognized throughout the research field for having played substantive, innovative, and most importantly, leading roles for both the scientific community and industry-leading companies in the area of his specialization. Moreover, [BENEFICIARY] has also received an oral presentation award at another high-ranking conference in YEAR for his groundbreaking work on X.

In another major contribution, [BENEFICIARY] proposed a new factor of merit to characterize inter-experimental effects. This model is likely to become widely adopted by many scientific communities to align their recorded data across experiments. It is already an essential component in further project pipelines in my own group. This is of key importance because, for instance, [impact of work]. Ultimately, [BENEFICIARY]'s outstanding research in this area will enable integration of data from different sources on a much larger scale than previously anticipated. Combined with his contributions to X, this really paves the way for significant advances in Y.

As described herein and based on publications, conference proceedings, awards, and his career progression, [BENEFICIARY]'s original research in the field of ABC has been a key enabler for the next generation of models. Peers and research leaders alike recognize him for his pioneering work. [BENEFICIARY]'s new concept of [Area of expertise] has powerfully impacted today's international research landscape in the scientific field of X and in aligned industries. For multiple years, [BENEFICIARY] has maintained an impressive level of international acclaim with continuous advancements as described in detail above. Therefore, I confirm that [BENEFICIARY] has established himself as a top researcher and scientist in his field and offer my strongest support of his designation as an expert of outstanding and extraordinary ability in the sciences. Please feel free to contact me if you have questions.

Yours Truly,

[RECOMMENDER'S NAME]

[JOB TITLE]

[ORGANIZATION]

Sample Letter #2: Professional Reference for Data Modeling Researcher

[LETTERHEAD]

[DATE]

Department of Homeland Security
U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services
Regional Service Center

Re: [NAME OF BENEFICIARY] – Support for Immigration Petition

To Whom It May Concern:

I offer this letter to emphasize my belief that [BENEFICIARY] possesses extraordinary ability in data science, which is expressed by her invaluable contributions to progress being made in [LIST AREA(S) OF EXPERTISE AND RESEARCH] today. The field of [List field(s) of applicant's expertise & accomplishment], which at its heart involves greatly improving and expanding the capabilities for data analytics, is exceedingly complex. It demands a high level of subject matter expertise and ingenuity to produce breakthroughs here.

As the introduction of higher-powered data modeling approaches has perplexed talented researcher scientists over the years, the relative few who find ways to solve these problems truly set themselves apart from peers by demonstrating an additional innovative spark. Thus, when I see a researcher of [BENEFICIARY'S] caliber present several critical contributions that are ready to greatly improve the performance of data modeling and predictive analytics infrastructure, I can confidently say that she functions at an elite level within the field. Her insightful problem-solving approach and ability to find creative solutions prove very hard to match. Her body of work has been influential to peer research, and she has become a respected member of the community as colleagues recognize the value of her contributions to effectively modeling and leveraging vast volumes of data. I have no reservations in recommending [BENEFICIARY] as a data scientist of an extraordinary nature.

In order to give full credibility to my assessment of [BENEFICIARY'S] abilities and my conclusion that her professional record is representative of a top member of our field, I provide you with a brief synopsis of my own background. I am [RECOMMENDER'S BIO GOES HERE]. My career roles have helped develop and establish new paradigms in data analytics and its applications in transportation, including in the areas of [List areas of accomplishment]. [BENEFICIARY] has proven her research in these areas to be brilliant and transformative.

I have not worked directly with [BENEFICIARY], but have followed her research endeavors for some time now. Her research is of hugely impressive quality, demonstrating a mastery of advanced quantitative techniques. It signifies important lessons for how data science can enable a range of cross-disciplinary applications, especially in transportation, to deliver more powerful insights and solutions. [BENEFICIARY'S] efforts to [LIST ORIGINAL CONTRIBUTION] were unprecedented. [EXPLAIN ORIGINAL CONTRIBUTION AND ITS IMPACT ON THE FIELD]. This research has been of great benefit to fellow scientists and is supporting the design of more effective data-driven solutions.

[BENEFICIARY'S] proposals to [LIST ANOTHER ORIGINAL CONTRIBUTION] are another indicator of astounding work and creative genius. [EXPLAIN CONTRIBUTION AND ITS IMPACT ON THE FIELD]. It is a drastic gain to say the least.

This groundbreaking research was culminated in a thoughtful and heavily influential paper ("TITLE OF PAPER") accepted for publication through the renowned [NAME OF JOURNAL/CONFERENCE]. It was well received, winning the esteemed [NAME OF] award from [ORGANIZATION]. While by no means the only excellent paper of her that has appeared in a prestigious venue, the attention earned by this publication makes it one of [BENEFICIARY'S] seminal contributions to data science to date, and rightfully so. It brought new perspective to [AREA OF EXPERTISE] – shown by the more than the 100 citations it has garnered thus far – and helped set a new direction in this area. [Alternatively, you can discuss major patents here if there are no published papers.]

As a testament to the breadth of her research impact, [BENEFICIARY] also carefully studied and offered keen answers for the [LIST ANOTHER ORIGINAL CONTRIBUTION]. She effectively addressed this obstacle by [EXPLAIN CONTRIBUTION AND ITS IMPACT ON THE FIELD]. This was a milestone for data analytic methods, and the fact that this solution was readily applicable made it an extremely important development for the field. This astute research project resulted in another informative paper titled "NAME OF PAPER" published through [NAME OF JOURNAL/CONFERENCE] and cited numerous times by other researchers.

Moreover, [BENEFICIARY] has explored and contributed crucial findings to [LIST ANOTHER ORIGINAL CONTRIBUTION]. In a seminal research project, she sought ways to [EXPLAIN CONTRIBUTION AND ITS IMPACT ON THE FIELD]. Her work generated tools to process data more comprehensively and drive more accurate insights. The endeavor served as a major step forward for large-scale data modeling capabilities. [BENEFICIARY'S] thorough research on this topic produced several critical research papers that have been published in leading data science conferences, such as [NAMES OF CONFERENCES], to which gaining acceptance is very competitive.

It is clear to me that [BENEFICIARY] has made major original contributions in [LIST AREA(S) OF EXPERTISE] research. These contributions are helping to redefine the ways we approach certain challenges in this field and have given us methods for combating them effectively. She has been recognized time and again for the value of this work – whether through awards or selection for publication in top venues after rigorous peer review. As stated above, data science presents problems that are difficult to master. To perform research as skillfully as

[BENEFICIARY] has, and devise solutions that have had this high a level of influence on the direction of cutting-edge data analytic approaches, requires exceptional capability and expertise. Given the significance of [BENEFICIARY'S] accomplishments, not to mention their novelty and inventiveness, I believe she definitely possesses extraordinary ability in data science. I recommend that you afford this same recognition.

Sincerely,

[RECOMMENDER'S NAME]

[JOB TITLE]

[ORGANIZATION]

Sample Letter #3: Independent Reference for Science Researcher

[Letterhead]

[Date]

Department of Homeland Security
U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services
Regional Service Center

Re: *[Name of beneficiary]* – Support for Immigration Petition

To Whom It May Concern:

I am pleased to submit this letter describing the outstanding professional qualifications of *[Beneficiary]* to support his U.S. visa application. Bluntly put, I believe that *[Beneficiary]* has extraordinary ability in the field of *[Specialization]*, based specifically on a fine body of research completed within *[List area(s) of expertise or research]*. This area is at the leading edge of efforts to *[purpose of specialization, applicability of research/technology]*. We have not worked together, but I have seen the high quality of his findings and their sizable impact on developments in this field. He possesses a heightened capacity for innovation, as demonstrated by a number of his research methods and proposals, and this innovation undoubtedly benefits peers' ability to effectively address problems that involve *[specialization]*. It is clear that he has carved an important place at the top of the field, and I want to take a few moments to discuss the game-changing nature of his work.

Before launching further into my assessment of *[Beneficiary]*, allow me to provide my credentials to evaluate his talent. I am currently *[Recommender's bio goes here, include info on current and previous roles, research specialties, number of publications and citations, number of patents, any awards or major honors, as applicable]*. Suffice it to say I am qualified to provide my observations that *[Beneficiary]* is an extraordinarily talented researcher.

[Beneficiary's] research has been easy to spot, because it has gained a place in the upper echelon of published material in the *[Area of expertise]* community. He has authored papers that were accepted to several esteemed venues that represent some of the most advanced research in *[Area of expertise]*, such as the scholarly journal *[Name of journal]* and top-tier conferences like the *[Names of conferences]*, which publish their own highly valued proceedings on which future research relies in the same way as a journal. All these publications challenge their audiences to think more deeply and less traditionally about demanding problems in *[Area of expertise]*; they publish papers that expand a reader's intellectual horizons and provide opportunities for new, exciting lines of research. It is definitely impressive for a young researcher like *[Beneficiary]* to have been published

in these forums this many times already. This shows that review committees find his approach fresh and intriguing, and that his research results are meaningful; to be published repeatedly is a sign that of always having something new to offer. Indeed, his solutions have helped shape the research of countless others who have referenced his work, and he has earned international respect for making innovative proposals. This is the mark of someone who is gifted in the study and development of data science concepts.

Of course, to fully demonstrate why [Beneficiary's] achievements have earned such praise, one must discuss what those achievements are and why they matter to [Area(s) of expertise]. It is best to start at [List original contribution] and examine the excellent work here. He engaged in an intensive analysis of [Explain contribution and its impact on the field] the likes of which had not been done before. The discoveries this yielded were something of a watershed for the field. This line of work has been a seminal achievement in his career. It has given scientists the tools and knowledge to develop more informed and robust solutions to a significant problem. His methods are described in the paper "Title of Paper," which was published at the venerated [Name of journal or conference].

Another area where [Beneficiary's] research has been critical is [List another original contribution]. He proposed and experimented with [Explain contribution and its impact on the field] This strategy became a U.S. patent, "Name of patent," with [Beneficiary] as one of the Inventors. This was a pioneering idea, and the patent helps indicate its usefulness. This landmark achievement further distinguishes [Beneficiary] and the weight of his contributions.

This admirable research was detailed in a paper by [Beneficiary] and colleagues titled "Name of paper". It was published through [Name of journal or conference], and has drawn heavy international attention, having been cited more than 150 times. It won the prestigious Best Paper award. It is among [Beneficiary's] preeminent contributions to data science, and is vital for its new perspective offered to [Area of expertise]. There is no doubt that these results are valuable to this field of study.

[Beneficiary] has furnished vital research that has impacted other disciplines. He keenly analyzed [List another original contribution]. He devised methods [Explain contribution and its impact on the field]. These solutions improved performance, showing that he had made a critical contribution toward [Area of expertise]. This fruitful research project was explained in another informative paper titled "Name of paper," which was accepted for publication in [Name of journal or conference].

In addition, [Beneficiary] has also created new opportunities to improve [List another original contribution]. He made strides toward [Explain contribution and its impact on the field]. His extensive research has generated critical information on [specific topics covered in research]. It also led to several insightful papers that were published in leading conferences, including [Names of conferences], which have highly competitive selection processes.

For all the insights his own research has given, [Beneficiary] has also helped ensure that the quality of other work carried out in our field is at the top level. Owing to his respected status as a

[*Area of expertise*] expert who has authored influential articles, he has been asked to review papers submitted to esteemed conferences and journals in the field. These include [*Names of journals and conferences*]. The purpose of these reviews is to help editors and conference organizers conclude whether a paper is worthy of selection for publication, which can be a very difficult process considering how strong many of these submissions are. Thus reviewers like [*Beneficiary*] are called upon to provide their critique of individual papers because they are regarded as best able to determine whether the content, presentation, and originality of a paper have truly met the high standards established by the venue. Thus, a paper that a reviewer deems acceptable for publication will assuredly demonstrate great impact and have something interesting to offer the field for consideration. By evaluating the work of his peers and deciding whether that impact is present in each paper reviewed, [*Beneficiary*] uses exceptional wisdom in [the specific field] and helps the general discourse among fellow researchers to remain innovative. Having served numerous conferences myself, I know that the work of our reviewers is of the utmost importance to ensuring that the quality of these forums is upheld.

It becomes clear that [*Beneficiary*] is hugely talented and has made original contributions to [*Area of expertise*] that help to greatly expand its possibilities. On multiple occasions his insights have served as a guide to fellow researchers and scientists, showing them new avenues to overcome analytic challenges or create better approaches to important problems. His understanding of [*Area of expertise*] is exceptional. The awards, published papers, and citations mentioned above show the high value our field gives his work. I believe that [*Beneficiary*] is a member of the [*Area of expertise*] profession with extraordinary ability, and give my full support to his visa application.

Sincerely,

Recommender's Name

Job Title

Organization